

Linux gaming is booming

Now the last Windows bastion is falling. The penguin can game!

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Linux has never been a popular gaming platform, and for some very good reasons. There are few commercial games on Linux, next to no AAA titles, poor open source drivers support and a community that can often be hostile to anything that is proprietary or closed. Do you need more? It's hard enough for Linux to be a gaming platform when there are no games for it; add to that the lack of compatibility between even major distributions, the sheer number of combinations of package formats, window managers, desktop environments, config variables and you know there's going to be trouble for games on Linux. Then there is the general impression that Linux users are a bunch of free-loaders unwilling to pay for a "proper" OS, and are unlikely to pay for anything else. What you have is the perfect recipe to keep away companies from catering to the platform. There are clearly a lot of problems when it comes to gaming on Linux, but that isn't why we wrote this article.

Voting with wallets

Everything, in the end, comes down to economics. If there are enough people willing to pay for it, then someone is likely to make it. Recent events have busted the myths that Linux users won't pay for software. We speak of course of the Humble Bundles and Kickstarter. For those unfamiliar with what we are talking about — how is it living under that giant rock? — here is a little intro: The Humble Bundles are collections of (usually Indie) games that are offered at a pay what you

want model for a limited amount of time. The requirements of each bundle are that the games must run on Windows, OSX and Linux and be DRM free. Also, part of the money — you decide how much — goes to charity.

In the thirteen bundles so far, one trend has emerged; Linux users pay on average more than Windows or Mac users, often by a healthy margin. The latest bundle saw Linux users contributing an average of \$12.50, while for Mac and Windows users the average was \$9.99 and \$8.53 respectively. Over 60 games have been part of Humble Bundles now, and sure, some of them were already available for Linux, but most have been ported to Linux just because of this. And they have all been high quality Indie games.

Kickstarter is another phenomenon, which connects people who have ideas

with people willing to pay for them. If you have an idea you need funding for, post it on Kickstarter, and if people like it they will back your project in return for rewards. You set a goal for how much you need and if it is met, your backers get charged and you get all the money. If your goal is missed, even by a single dollar, you get nothing, and the backers pay nothing. Recently there have been a number of high-profile successes on Kickstarter, and most have at least one thing in common. Yes, you guessed it right, they're all named after Roman gods. Err, sorry, those are the planets. Most of those games are coming for Linux. Here's a list of some of the games (and how much asked for and raised) coming for Linux soon:

- Double Fine Adventure (asked: \$400,000, got: \$3.3 million)
- Wasteland 2 (asked: \$900,000, got: \$2.9 million)
- Shadowrun Returns (asked: \$400,000, got: \$1.8 million)
- The Banner Sage (asked: \$100,000 got: \$723,886)
- The Leisure Suit Larry remake (asked: \$500,000, got: \$655,182)
- Carmageddon (asked: \$400,000, got: \$625,143)

These are just some of the ones that made the most money. There are other smaller games such as Word Realms, Drifter, Nekro, and many others that have included Linux support. It isn't just some noble venture, the backers asked for it, they made it a condition for giving more money or for giving money at all. They voted with their wallets and results were achieved.

New avenues

App stores are a "recent" trend, but Linux has had something similar for a very long



Desura game centre



Another good game in this ecosystem: Trine2